

JKBOSE 2026

CLASS 11TH

FATHER TO SON

LECTURE-1

ENGLISH

HUSSAIN SIR



Topics To Covered

- 1 ... Lec. 01 (Father to Son)
 - ⇒ Detailed explanation.
- 2 ...
 - ⇒ Stanza wise Summary.
 - ⇒ Textual questions.
- 3 ...
 - ⇒ Poetic Devices.
- 4 ...

Elizabeth Jennings



Elizabeth Jennings (1926–2001) was a well-known English poet. Her poems are known for their simplicity, emotional depth, and focus on personal relationships, *close relations among the people*, love, and faith. She often wrote about human feelings and conflicts in everyday life. In her poem “Father to Son,” she explores the pain of emotional distance between a father and his son.

Father to Son



→ Father

I do not understand this child

Though we have lived together now

In the same house for years. I know

Nothing of him, so try to build

Up a relationship from how

He was when small. Yet have I killed

→ Narrator ⇒ Father

The father begins by expressing his sorrow and confusion. He says that he doesn't understand his own son, despite living in the same house for years. Their relationship has become so distant that the father feels like he knows nothing about him. He ^{desires} longs to rebuild their lost bond by recalling how close they were when the son was a child.

QUESTION

What does the father confess in the first stanza?

- 1 He is proud of his son ✗
- 2 He knows his son well ✗
- 3 He wants to punish his son ✗
- 4 He does not understand his son ~~✗~~

QUESTION



What is the father's tone in this stanza?

- 1** Sad and regretful ~~✓~~
- 2** Humorous
- 3** Angry
- 4** Joyful

QUESTION



What does the father want to do?

- 1 Send his son away
- 2 Rebuild their relationship ~~XXXX~~
- 3 Ignore his son
- 4 Get him married

Father to Son

Yet have I Killed

The seed I spent or sown it where

The land is his and none of mine?

We speak like strangers, there's no sign

Of understanding in the air.

This child is built to my design

Yet what he loves I cannot share.

metaphor
enjoyment

simile

resemble

Killed the seed: Failed to raise the child properly (metaphor)

Sown: Planted (used metaphorically)

Land is his: The son's world or personality

Built to my design: Resembling the father, genetically or outwardly

Share: To have in common

The father now questions himself. He wonders if he is to blame for this gap – has he “killed the seed,” meaning has he failed in raising his son with love and care? Or has he planted the seed (his upbringing) in a land that doesn't belong to him – the son's world, thoughts, and interests? They now speak like strangers and don't share mutual understanding. Although the son is physically and biologically like the father (“built to my design”), the father cannot relate to the son's likes, interests, or world.

QUESTION

What does “seed I spent” metaphorically refer to?

- 1 A real seed
- 2 The father's money
- 3 The father's upbringing of his son ~~✗~~
- 4 A seed in his garden

QUESTION



What does “land is his and none of mine” suggest?

- 1 The son is from another country
- 2 The son is emotionally distant ~~XXXX~~
- 3 The father owns no land
- 4 The son dislikes nature

QUESTION



How do the father and son communicate now?

- 1 Like close friends
- 2 Through gestures only
- 3 Like strangers 
- 4 Very frequently and warmly

Father to Son



→ Abandonment
Silence surrounds us. I would have
Him prodigal, returning to
His father's house, the home he knew,
Rather than see him make and move
His world. I would forgive him too,
Shaping from sorrow a new love.

Silence surrounds us: Complete lack of communication

Prodigal: A son who leaves but returns repentant (Biblical reference)

Home he knew: Childhood home where he belonged

Make and move his world: Create his own separate life

Forgive: To pardon mistakes or differences

Shaping from sorrow a new love: Creating a new bond from past pain

Now, silence dominates their relationship – they don't talk meaningfully anymore. The father wishes that his son would return to him like the Prodigal Son from the Bible – even if he has made mistakes. He prefers having him back and forgiving him than seeing him create a completely separate life. The father is willing to forgive and start over, transforming his sorrow into renewed love.

QUESTION



What dominates the father-son relationship here?

- 1 Laughter
- 2 Silence ~~XXXX~~
- 3 Violence
- 4 Conversation

QUESTION

What does the father mean by “I would have him prodigal”?

- 1 He wants him to leave
- 2 He wants to punish him
- 3 He wants him to become rich
- 4 He wants him to return with repentance 

Father to Son



Father and son, we both must live
On the same globe and the same land,
Son
He speaks: I cannot understand
Myself, why anger grows from grief.
We each put out an empty hand,
Longing for something to forgive.

In the final stanza, the father says that both father and son must live in the same world and must somehow co-exist, even if they are emotionally apart. The son finally speaks and admits that he doesn't understand himself, and he is confused why his grief (sadness) is turning into anger. Both father and son want to reach out, but their efforts seem empty. They both silently long to forgive each other and heal the emotional gap.

QUESTION



What does the son admit in this stanza?

- 1 He dislikes his father
- 2 He doesn't understand himself ~~XXXX~~
- 3 He wants to run away
- 4 He is angry

QUESTION



What causes the son's anger?

1 Love

2 Joy

3 Grief



4 Ambition

QUESTION



What do both father and son do in the end?

- 1 Fight
- 2 Leave the house
- 3 Celebrate
- 4 ~~Put out empty hands, hoping for forgiveness~~

QUESTION



Does the poem talk of ail exclusively personal experience or is it fairly universal?

ANSWER:

The poem is autobiographical in nature and describes the relationship between a father and his son. Beginning on an exclusively personal experience, the poem rises to a fairly universal phenomenon—the growing generation gap and lack of communication.

QUESTION



How is the father's helplessness brought out in the poem?

ANSWER:

The father's helplessness is brought about by the existing circumstances. Usually a father is the best friend and advisor of the son. However, there is no bond of affinity or relationship between the two. It seems that the two are not on speaking terms even while living under the same roof. The father feels helpless that he can't share what his son loves.

QUESTION



Identify the phrases and lines that indicate distance between father and son.

ANSWER:

The phrases/lines indicating distance between father and son are:

“I don’t understand this child.”

“I know nothing of him.”

“We speak like strangers, there’s no sign
Of understanding in the air.”

“..What he loves I cannot share.”

“Silence surrounds us.”

“...see him make and move His world.”

QUESTION

Does the poem have a consistent rhyme scheme?

ANSWER:

No, the poem does not have a consistent rhyme scheme. The first two stanzas have the rhyme-scheme ab ba ba whereas the third and fourth have a slight alteration. The third stanza has abc aba whereas the fourth one has abbcb scheme. →

Summary



Theme of the poem:

- ① Generation gap.
- ② Lack of communication.
- ③ Family conflict
- ④ Love and forgiveness.
- ⑤ Emotional distance between father and Son.

Thank
You